

KYRIANNA

The ever-present discomfort of a chronic condition is difficult to capture, but essential to understanding pain as an aspect of the human condition. KYRIANNA expresses her experience with back pain with intense works that recall those surrealist paintings that step outside the societal boundaries of what is normal. With penetrating self-portraits and enlightened portraits of others accompanied by interview-informed descriptions of chronic-condition experiences, she reveals those deeply felt conditions described but rarely seen. Watercolor and mixed-media artist KYRIANNA Bolles has created powerful portraits that, with a surreal directness recalling Kahlo's approach, address the intensity of her chronic pain and its accompanying effects. Experiencing debilitating back pain since age twelve, associated with spinal stenosis, she has had little success with remedies and often encounters a lack of empathy or understanding because she does not present with visible symptoms. Like many people with invisible disabilities, KYRIANNA often finds herself alone, working through the pain. KYRIANNA's portraits extend to many others with chronic conditions. After discovering their profound unique experiences through an interview process she refers to as "therapeutic visualization," she captures them with a vivid starkness that reveals their hidden realities, often with surrealist visual metaphors.

—Timothy W. Hiles, *Art, Movement, and Disability: Transcending the Beauty Paradigm*, (New York: Routledge Press, 2026), p.6, 96.

KYRIANNA has worked with many different people of all ages and backgrounds. Each demographic and each person faces a unique set of difficulties that make each portrait varied on many levels.

In order to create these portraits KYRIANNA has a several-step interview process. The voice of the subject is ultimately the most important piece here, so she begins by going through a loose, two page questionnaire that allows her to hear various aspects of their journey, e.g. When did your symptoms begin? Do you have a diagnosis? How has it affected your mental health and relationships with others? etc. This is one of the most crucial parts. Most clients share that they have never had anyone ask them about their conditions and really listen and care about what they had to say. There's opportunity for catharsis just in that.

KYRIANNA has strong visions of visual metaphors for her self-portraits. She guides the people she works with through a process where they can come up with their own idea of how to visualize their symptoms in a way that feels genuine and authentic to them. Each person should leave the project feeling seen and heard, and having a visual articulation of their condition that allows perhaps for more understanding from the people around them, as well as personal validation of what can at times be a frustratingly intangible struggle.